

of marble used, gives some sort of justification for the famous and universally deplored "cadaverous white" of the monument. Yet, to summarize, the main value of the book is in the immersion which it permits into a period of Italian life not as widely explored as its great interest might warrant. Italian history has always been quite peculiar; the period immediately following Italy's appearance on the world stage as a unified and "modern" country is, both for positive and for negative reasons, among the most fascinating. Here we are reminded of some of the period's significant events and of many of its major and minor characters. Incidentally, and to end on a pedantic note, Italian typography could have done better with the illustrations, extremely well-chosen and interesting as they are; and an Index of Names would have been welcome. [P. M. P.]

THE MAESTRO

As a light informal biography of Arturo Toscanini, *The Magic Baton* (New York: G. P. Putnam's Sons, 1957) by Filippo Sacchi is well conceived and well composed. It sketches, incisively and authoritatively, the trajectory of his public career from the momentous night in Rio de Janeiro when at the age of nineteen he mounted the podium and conducted the whole of *Aida*, to the last days in Riverdale when at the age of eighty-nine he was editing just before his

death his recorded performance of *Aida*. Though it is quite properly the story of extraordinary talent, luck, and implacable will, it is also an historical evocation of the cultural past. Our memory of Toscanini is still so fresh that we may be inadvertently surprised at recalling that his eminence at La Scala dates from 1898 and that by 1908 he, an Italian, had commanded a free hand at the utterly Teutonic Metropolitan. Indeed, when he began to conduct opera, the manners and attitudes he eventually succeeded in remolding (the obsessive and irrelevant social associations of opera, the tyranny of the public and the *prime donne*, the operatic tradition of Bellini and his epigones) were the direct inheritance of the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries.

Inevitably, Mr. Sacchi intrigues his reader with bits of social history, which are properly subordinated in context, but which resound more authentically than the actual character of his subject (a friend, a figure recently dead and therefore venerable) whose full lineaments cannot be traced at this short distance in history. One is grateful for the evocation of nineteenth-century Parma, for the characterization of Toscanini's passionately *garibaldino* father, and for the whole life of music in those days, marginally but vividly suggested. Layers are properly distinguished: the age of Bellini and Stendhal, the complacency and then the revolu-

tion of the middle of the century, imported "diabolism", and the emergence of a new age: "Even Boito—the Boito whom we have all known, old, loaded with honours, senator, president of academies, ornament of aristocratic salons—had taken hashish in his youth." We may be moved by Toscanini's devotion to his friend, the fated Catalani; we may also marvel, in a mingling of amusement and pathos, at how sharply the libretto of his *Edmea* evokes the age. "Edmea is a sort of Ophelia of the Elbe. When the brave Oberto departs she is forced by his father to marry Ulmo. She throws herself into the river and, when fished out by her husband, is found to have gone mad and wanders around, dressed like a fantastic water-fairy, until the end, when she falls into the arms of the inconsolable Oberto and recovers her reason; poor Ulmo poisons himself to allow them to marry, begging Edmea for the supreme gift of a kiss on the forehead; not at once—that would be asking too much—but after his death."

Yet the true subject is Toscanini the great conductor. The reader will be fascinated by the glimpses of complexity in the character of the lower-class musician from Parma: his deep sympathy for Catalani and the eccentric painter Grubicy, his espousal and conflict with the post-Verdian school as represented antithetically by Puccini and Pizzetti, his embarrassed support of the early

socialist Mussolini and his later resistance to fascism, and generally his unflinching refusal to tolerate sloth, failure, unprincipled behavior, and stupidity. He was both an innovator and a traditionalist, a harsh disciplinarian and a selfless servant of music, a family man and a philanderer. An intimate revelation of the book is his tender solicitude for his natural son by Rosina Storchio, who after having lived "completely palsied and speechless", died at the age of sixteen. When the time is ripe, Mr. Sacchi's memoir will be one of the cornerstones of the eventual definitive biography.

[L. N.]

THE INCOMPARABLE GADDA

The most important fictional work of the season, indeed perhaps of the year, has come from a writer of the older generation, Carlo Emilio Gadda, born in 1893, or more exactly, as he puts it, fourteen days before the fall of the first Giolitti cabinet. He was better known, until now at least, in highly literate circles than among the ordinary fiction-reading public, difficult as that public may be to identify as a class, especially in Italy. This time, the support of a publisher whose commercial acumen is a trademark may have helped Gadda considerably; it remains to be seen whether his conquest of a wider public is a permanent one.

The novel confronts us, in a more emphatic form than pos-

sibly any before, with the question of the relationship between the national and the vernacular in Italian fiction. The very title, *Quer pasticciaccio brutto de Via Merulana* (Milan: Garzanti, 1957), which can be approximately rendered as "That Ugly Mess on the Via Merulana", is not in general Italian but in local Roman speech; and so are large portions not only of the dialogue but of the narrative as well. Nor is Roman the only local parlance that is adopted here: the protagonist's regional peculiarities (his region is Molise) are taken into account; and so are the speech peculiarities of other characters. That the *pasticciaccio* of the title, referring more directly to the unsolved crimes which constitute its principal items of plot, may have a subsidiary, symbolic reference to the *pastiche* of style, is a tempting supposition. It should be added that the use of vernacular, of some vernacular, suggests in this writer the need for a language that he feels is richer and more pliable and expressive, rather than the simple desire to tape-record the "typical"; for instance in a previous work, *Adalgisa*, the texture of his language had been fortified by injections of Milanese. Readers of the present book especially acquainted with the individual local languages have detected questionable details in Gadda's Roman vernacular, and the same is true in passages of other local colors (there are even some lines of

Venetian); but everyone agrees that the question is artistically irrelevant. The final concoction is unique. The strong dialect elements overflow, so to speak, out of the spoken lines of dialogue and invade the normal narrative territories, the description of characters and their actions; in a sort of oblique interior speech the characters produce, as it were, the brand of narrative which relentlessly follows them.

In a rather special sense this novel could have been a thriller, or what is known in Italy as a yellow book; but there has never been a story-teller to whom the structure of suspense-and-discovery seemed to matter less, or a crime novel where final detection appeared as a more secondary concern. In fact, though there are strong suspicions, the question of who did it is unanswered. Even more, the whole plot seems like an excuse for building around it an extraordinary verbal structure and a fascinating evocation of *milieu* and time.

The *milieu* is Rome, and centrally at first a large apartment house inhabited by members of that well-to-do merchant class known locally as *il generone*. Two crimes are committed in the fated building on the via Merulana, one a burglary, with theft of jewels at the expense of a countess Menegazzi; the other, the ferocious and unexplained murder of a lady, Lilianna Balducci. Much of this is seen, after the fact, through the eyes of the police officer, head of the so-called Mobile

Squad, in charge of the investigation, Francesco ("don Ciccio") Ingravallo, the book's main character, whose speech therefore determines large sections of the narrative: the description of the body as it is found, and the subsequent pages (62 ff.) with don Ciccio's first reactions and considerations, are an unforgettable example of the way Gadda masters his "contamination" of styles. The novel is then occupied with an analysis of the police interrogations in vain search for the culprits, presenting us with that sequence of types, from investigators to young and suspect bullies, from bourgeois ladies to prostitutes, which constitutes the main bulk and the chief attraction of the work. Characters like la Zamira (p. 179 ff. and 246 ff.) or even single visions like that of Dr. Fumi coughing (p. 120) or that of don Ciccio himself emerging from his bed in the early morning (p. 322 ff.) are definitive, unquestionably successful results of Gadda's method, of his unique amalgam of the folksy and the highly literate.

The period of action is 1927, with the shadow of autocracy already thick on the political horizon; the general atmosphere is subtly conditioned by this, and the *duce* himself is frequently referred to through picturesque circumlocutions. Two such *milieu* passages, hardly translatable at all, may be as good instances as any of Gadda's various manners: "Vigeva ora il vigor nuovo del

Mascellone, Testa di Morto in bombetta, poi Emiro col fez, e col pennacchio, e la nuova castità della baronessa Malacianca-Fasulli, la nuova legge delle verghe a fascio. Pensare che ce fossero dei ladri, a Roma, ora? Co quer gallinaccio co la faccia fanatica a Palazzo Chiggi? Cor Federzoni che voleva carcerà pe forza tutti li storcioni de lungotevere? e quanno che se sbaciucchiaveno ar cinema? tutti li cani in fregola de la Lungara? Cor Papa milanese e co l'Anno Santo de du anni prima? E co li sposi novelli? Co li polli novelli a scarpinà pe tutta Roma?" (p. 81). And a little later on a very different linguistic vein: "Le nuove forze operanti nella società italiana quel rinnovamento profondo che, atteggiandosi alla antica severità o almeno alla faccia severa de' littori, aveva però già preso l'aire dalla loro dotazione di bastoncelli . . . si addiedero poi senza sciuparsi nei filosofemi (primum vivere) a lastricare de' più verbosi buoni propositi la patente via dell'inferno. Cassificate indi a funeraria minaccia e fattesi verbo e vento. . . ." and so on, the narrator in this case having started on his literate and occasionally mock-antiquated and mock-scientific vein. Space does not allow to go into Gadda's biography and career; a relative late-comer to the world of letters, he started his life, and lived a good part of it, as an engineer.

In the ordinary sense, as we have indicated, the *Pasticciaccio*

cio presents no conclusion. While plot-wise this could be entirely acceptable, some readers have justifiably deplored here a final impression of formlessness. A not uncommon reaction is that the reader is confronted with a series of set pieces. But discussion on this work has been, and will continue to be, lively and fruitful. On the whole, it seems that Gadda will remain as an extraordinarily attractive and original case, rather than as a more usable lesson in how to solve some of the problems (in language, in relation to milieu, etc.) that are peculiar to the Italian novelist of our time. [P. M. P.]

PIRANDELLO IN PAPERBACK

Everyman's Library has a habit of transformation: first it was a change in binding, then in size, and now the inevitable, a new series of paperbacks. Among the first ten titles is Pirandello, *Naked Masks*, ed. Eric Bentley (New York: Dutton): five plays, including *Liola*, together with the preface (1925) to *Six Characters*, an introduction, a biographical summary, and a good selective bibliography. The introduction is directed against the emphasis often placed on Pirandello's "ideas" in isolation from his plays. Pirandello is not propounding "ideas" but rather presenting dramatically a view of the world and of particular instances of humanity in his characters. "There is nothing

in world drama resembling such characters," writes Mr. Bentley. "They fall from the sky, they are whirled hither and yon, they cry out in anguish, they sink into the ground. But is not this, in its way, highly dramatic?" Especially good and suggestive are the editor's remarks on Pirandello's dramatic rhetoric. "His strongest weapon is his prose. Its torrential eloquence and pungent force are unique in the whole range of modern drama. . . . He gets effects which one would not have thought possible to colloquial prose. . . ." Not only the contemporary critic, but also the practicing dramatist should be alerted.

One may hope that Archibald Colquhoun's excellent translation of *I promessi sposi*, in hardcover Everyman's Library since 1956, may be given a softer back and price, and so made readily available to the traveler, the drugstore browser, and especially those in charge of college courses in the European novel: the reader of English may now for the first time read a decent and complete version of Manzoni. [L. N.]

THE LUXURY OF TEARS

Children of the Shadows (Doubleday: Garden City, New York, 1957), by the Australian writer, Morris L. West, is an excellent piece of reportage. His subject is the *scugnizzi* of Naples, the homeless children who learn from the age of seven or so to keep themselves

alive by their wits, scavenging, pimping, begging, stealing, literally anything. It is, of course, part of the interminable history of the martyrdom of children: not those who are covertly tortured at home, but rather those who are deprived, for all to see, of shelter, food, dignity, not to mention love, through what amounts to a conspiracy of society. In the absence of governmental interest, adequate private or ecclesiastical charity, a plucky priest, Mario Borelli, after obtaining the permission of Cardinal Ascalesi, disguised himself as a *scugnizzo*, gained the confidence of a band of urchins, and became in effect a missionary in the midst of Naples. It was only after months of living their degraded life that he felt he could risk revealing his true identity as a priest, overcome their worldly fear and suspicion, and lead them from their naked existence into a refuge he had fashioned from a bombed-out church, a place they would be free to frequent, where they could find food and shelter without obligation, where eventually they might come to know companionship, security, trust, and even Christ. That, Padre Borelli's mission, is the core of the book; and that, apparently, is just about the way things stand today.

What is it that causes and perpetuates such horrifying poverty and loneliness and

brutality? According to the author, it is a web of governmental corruption and mismanagement, the indifference or exploitation of the rich, the conservatism and even the puritanism of the southern Church. Since he finds the situation an impasse, apart from the efforts of valiant people, very few, like Padre Borelli, Mr. West would propose, in brief, that the children, the *scugnizzi*, be got out of the hopeless sink of Naples and sent to the still growing frontiers of the world, to Canada, the United States, Australia, Africa, where they could be trained to live useful, wholesome, independent lives. But, as of the time of writing his book, he had found little concrete encouragement; the American consul in Naples, for example, confined himself to reiterating the sacrosanct quota of 5,645 per annum. Actually, it is clear that he must depend upon the effect of his book to arouse interest and raise funds. It could be a mission for Americans of Italian descent to look back upon the long, often humiliating, struggle up from degradation, and not in denial but in proud acknowledgment of their forebears, to dedicate their efforts to the redemption of the helpless *scugnizzi* of Naples. The reader of this book may often be moved to tears. The homeless urchin of Naples soon learns to dispense with that luxury. [L. N.]